



DOON TUNE Clockwise from left, writer Saumya Kulshreshtha; William Dalrymple at the DDLF curtain-raiser in Delhi, Oct. 20; filmmaker Imtiaz Ali at a past edition

LITERATURE

CELEBRATING WORDS

The sixth edition of the **Dehradun Literature Festival** promises a convergence of literature, cinema and societal issues



A discussion with the audience at DIFF 2023







A still from *We Are Faheem and Karun*

The Dehradun Literature Festival (DDLF), founded by Samraant Virmani, offers a refreshing space for literary and cultural dialogue in a tech-driven world. Inspired by a personal moment when Virmani's daughter mistook a book's illustration for a touchscreen, the festival was conceived as a "meaningful pause" from technology.

Mentored by Ruskin Bond, filmmaker Vishal Bhardwaj and director Imtiaz Ali, DDLF has grown to become a significant cultural event. This year's edition (November 8-10, 2024; Doon International School) brings together over 70 renowned figures, including filmmaker Anupama Chopra, author Jerry Pinto, Bollywood icon Shabana Azmi, Olympic gold medallist Abhinav Bindra, chef Saransh Goila and historian William Dalrymple.

Dehradun serves as the perfect backdrop. "The city has a tradition of intellectual excellence and literary history that I felt needed to be honoured," says Virmani. His vision for the festival is not just to celebrate literature, but also foster an environment where the next generation can think critically and creatively. Virmani aims to inspire young minds in the city to appreciate human connection and critical thought.

DDLF founder **Samraant Virmani**'s vision was to foster an environment where the next generation can think creatively

This year's theme, 'Sahitya, Cinema, Samaaj,' reflects the festival's mission to bridge literature, film, and societal issues. "These are not isolated entities; they are interconnected streams that shape our perceptions and inspire change," explains Virmani. The festival curates panels and discussions that explore these intersections. One of the highlights, 'From Love to Madness', delves into how timeless themes like love and identity are reimagined in films such as *Laila Majnu*. Another panel, 'Writing Women for the Screen', examines how female stories are portrayed in cinema and their societal impact.

Curating this convergence of literature, cinema and society is central to the festival's ethos. "We ensure that these mediums engage in dynamic dialogue," says Virmani. "Each panel is crafted to highlight the intersections between these forms."

DDLF is a celebration of storytelling and the profound impact of literature and culture in our digital age. Through its curated panels, inspiring themes, and dedication to nurturing young minds, DDLF is carving out a unique place in India's literature festival landscape. ■

–Nikhil Sardana